

Player Guide — Combat & Exploration

Your stats, then how combat and exploration actually work at the table. The rest of character creation — background, and how the starting deck gets drafted — lives in `rules/character-creation.md`.

The Stats

All characters begin with Body 2 / Mind 2 / Soul 2, then distribute 3 more points among the three — no stat above 5 at character creation.

STAT	COLORS YOUR DAMAGE	ALSO DRIVES
Body	Red cards	Max HP = (3 × Body) + Soul + Mind
Mind	Blue cards	Hand size = Mind (minimum 2); also feeds Max HP
Soul	Green cards	Initiative = 1d6 + Soul; also feeds Max HP

A card's color determines which stat powers its damage, no matter which stat is highest on your sheet. Stats also decide which mode you use for checks, saves, and perception (Part Two) — a spread built around Soul reads rooms and holds oaths, around Mind anticipates and controls, around Body endures, positions, and breaks things. Your stat spread is a statement about how your character solves problems.

Part One: Combat

Full mechanics — positioning, turn structure, attack resolution, damage, reading a card, status effects, collapse and death — live in `rules/combat.md`. Read that for how a fight actually works.

How much you get to decide about what a card looks like when you play it: `rules/character-creation.md`, Magic Expression.

Part Two: Exploration

Checks, saves, perception, and Advantage/Disadvantage outside of combat: `rules/resolution.md`.

Between Fights

Resting

Short and long rest durations, limits, and what they clear: `rules/character-creation.md`, Resting.

Equipment

Slots, what carries a permanent effect, and the full item catalog: `rules/character-creation.md` (Equipment), `rules/equipment.md`, and `rules/items.md`.

What You Showed Up With

You choose what your character wears and what they carry. A sword, a bow, a walking stick, a good coat, a set of tools, whatever fits the person you made.

None of it has stats. None of it has a gold value. Your starting garb and weapon are not equipment in the mechanical sense — they grant no bonus, occupy no slot, and cannot be sold. Nobody is going to ask you what your sword's damage is. The cards are your damage. The gear is who you are.

It still matters, constantly. Not in a fight — out of one. What you happen to be carrying is a standing answer to problems the world puts in front of you, and the GM will take it seriously:

- A sword can dig. It can pry, wedge a door, cut a rope at arm's length, and reach something you'd rather not reach with your hand.
- A bow can shoot out a light across a room you don't want to cross.
- A heavy coat is a rope, a sack, a way to carry something too hot to hold, or the reason the cold doesn't get a check out of you.

So choose it as fiction, then use it as leverage. The character who thought about what they brought will find more doors open than the one who wrote "sword" and stopped thinking about it. That is the whole design: no numbers on it, real consequences from it.

The Oracle (End of Session)

At the close of every session, each player meets the Oracle alone. She speaks in three frames — **Name, Price, Distance** — and you'll hear the GM use those words at the table. She asks you something real and you answer it. She shows you a piece of what growth could look like, and you don't get to keep it — not yet. Then she offers you a genuine choice among a few real options, and whatever you choose becomes a permanent part of your deck.

Growth is never handed over whole. Where this actually happens, and what it's like to sit across from her, is worth meeting for yourself rather than reading about in advance.

Promotion

A card played enough, meaningfully, can become a Passive beyond your starting two — the Oracle's own way of recognizing what a character has already shown itself to be.

Nothing converts. A promoted Passive is authored fresh, in the fixed Passive shape (`rules/character-creation.md` , Passives) — not a stat translation of the card that earned it. The old card's specific die, Effect, and Defensive Bonus don't survive; what survives is what the card meant. STRIKE promoted isn't a d4 version of STRIKE — it's a new Passive built around whatever STRIKE revealed about the character who kept playing it.

Not every card clears that bar. A card with a real fictional throughline about identity — not just a good trick — is what Promotion is for. A card that's purely a mechanical maneuver, with nothing to say about who the character *is*, doesn't become a Passive just because it got played a lot; that kind of heavy use is better rewarded another way — a Bonus Card, a Distance pick that leans into it.

The retiring card returns to the GM/Oracle pool, same as any card leaving a deck permanently.

Promotion isn't the only door. A Passive can also be granted directly, GM's call, when the fiction earns it outright — a fusion, an awakening, a bond taking hold — with no card involved at all. That's the same authority that lets a character start with a Passive at creation with no play history behind it yet; Promotion is just the version of that authority that runs through a card already in play.